

INDIA'S WEB3, CRYPTO AND BLOCKCHAIN REALITY CHECK

WHAT'S AT STAKE BEYOND JUST TECH

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There's no shortage of hype when it comes to Web3, crypto, and blockchain – buzzwords that promise decentralized utopias and radical transparency. Be that as it may, the reality in India is starkly different, where immense potential meets stubborn, systemic challenges. Based on expert insights, a picture has emerged of India's fintech future, one that reveals a tapestry of innovation interwoven with regulatory and usability hurdles.

control in supply chains to securing educational credentials and revolutionizing financial transactions. Yet, she reminds us that the raw promise of immutable ledgers and decentralized trust is just the beginning.

Echoing this sentiment, Neha Dhir, Founder & Principal Attorney at BlockLegal.io, emphasizes, "Transparency, immutability, and security of blockchain are driving consumer acceptance." Neha's perspective underscores a critical point that the very features which make block-

The practical hurdles are many, and as Prashanth Ramdas, Partner at Khaitan & Co, explains, "The biggest obstacle remains usability and accessibility." Prashanth draws a parallel with India's transformative journey with UPI – a system that took digital payments from an idea to an everyday reality by focusing on simplicity and trust. He argues that if Web3 apps can strip away the intimidating layers of blockchain wallets, cryptographic keys, and technical jargon, they could replicate UPI's success by offering intuitive, secure, and user-friendly experiences.

This is the crux of India's Web3 conundrum. The promise is enormous, full of supply chain transparency, automated smart contracts, low-cost cross-border transactions via DeFi, and even the protection of creative intellectual property through NFTs. Yet, the barriers to entry remain high, particularly for non-tech-savvy users. As Prashanth puts it, "To make Web3 accessible, the primary focus should be on simplifying user experience and building trust. Interfaces must be simple, available in regional languages, and cater to varying literacy levels. Instilling confidence and awareness through initiatives driven by Common Service Centers (CSCs) and developing decentralized apps (dApps) of existing platforms can reduce fear and hesitation."

In a country where over 22 official languages coexist with varied literacy levels, the challenge isn't just technolog-

"India's consumer appetite for Web3 is massive, spanning transport, logistics, banking, education, fashion, gaming, healthcare, and even agriculture," highlights Shefali Pahwa, Managing Partner at BlockLegal.io. Shefali's bullish on the enormous promise of blockchain technology in transforming everyday life – from ensuring fair pricing and quality

chain attractive – its unalterable record-keeping and transparent operations – are key to building trust in an ecosystem where fraud and opacity have long been the norm. But while these qualities are laudable, they also come with a set of formidable challenges, especially when the technology is tasked with servicing a country as vast and diverse as India.

